

The Tell-Tale Heart

Edgar Allan Poe · 1843

First published: The Pioneer, Jan 1843

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

Liber et Libri · Lux et Libri LLC

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Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
4. Whole-book test and answer key
5. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/The_Works_of_the_Late_Edgar_Allan_Poe_(1850)/Volume_1/The_Tell-Tale_Heart (revision 14833580), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 7–12 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). Middle School prompts use the full text when the grade tags include 6–8; otherwise teacher-selected passages. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 1 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does The Tell-Tale Heart suggest about guilt and conscience?
- What does The Tell-Tale Heart suggest about the unreliable mind?
- What does The Tell-Tale Heart suggest about obsession?

Objectives

- Cite textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly and implicitly.
- Determine themes and analyze their development over the course of the story.
- Analyze how characters, setting and point of view interact.
- Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in the text.
- Write arguments to support claims with clear reasons and relevant evidence.

Standards and frameworks

- **Common Core:** RL.7.2, RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.7.1, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4
  Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org
- **Indiana 2023:** 7.RC.2, 7.RC.3, 7.W.1, 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.RC.2, 9-10.RC.3, 9-10.RC.9, 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.4, 11-12.RC.11, 11-12.RC.13, 11-12.W.1
  Indiana Academic Standards, English/Language Arts (2023), IDOE

- **Dual Credit (Indiana College Core):** ICC-WC-1.1, ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.7
  Indiana College Core, Written Communication outcomes 1.1–1.7 (CHE guidance); ICC-WC-x IDs are ours
- **AP:** AP-LIT.CHR, AP-LIT.SET, AP-LIT.STR, AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.FIG, AP-LIT.LAN
  AP English Literature and Composition big ideas (our summaries; apcentral.collegeboard.org)
- **Cambridge International:** CAIE-9695.AO1, CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4, CAIE-9695.AO5
  Cambridge International AS & A Level Literature in English 9695 assessment objectives (our summaries; cambridgeinternational.org)
- **Liber et Libri program outcomes:** LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1
  Liber et Libri program outcome, not an official standard

Primary codes: RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.5, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, RL.7.2
Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five
Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Middle School through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	The Tell-Tale Heart	1 × 90 min (90 min)	*guilt and conscience* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: The Tell-Tale Heart

Focus: guilt that the mind cannot hide

Content note (murder and dismemberment, described briefly): Sensitive content: Murder and dismemberment, described briefly. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes murder and dismemberment, described briefly.
Suggested language: "Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?"

Teacher only · spoilers

An unnamed narrator insists he is sane while describing how the old man's pale blue 'vulture eye' drove him to murder. He spies on the old man for seven nights, kills him on the eighth, dismembers the body and hides it under the floorboards. When police arrive he chats calmly, but a beating sound he believes is the dead man's heart grows louder until he shrieks a confession.

Background: Poe published the story in 1843. Insanity was a live legal question: the 1843 M'Naghten case in Britain set the test for an insanity defense in the same year. Poe's narrators often argue their own case.

Significance: It is one of the most taught examples of an unreliable first-person narrator; every claim of calm reason undercuts itself.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Respond in writing to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Settle in and write for five minutes: The narrator keeps telling us he is not mad. Why might someone insist so hard on a point? No wrong answers yet; we will test these ideas against the text. Two volunteers share, and I note key words on the board. Before we start, a content note: Heads-up: this story includes murder and dismemberment, described briefly.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Introduce 5 key words: pronounce, define from context, then the word's history.
Today's words are dismembered, suavity, dissemble, dissimulation, uncontrollable. For each one we read the sentence, guess from context and then check the definition. Here is the first: "First of all I dismembered the corpse." In this sentence it means: cut a body into pieces. Word histories: For the other words, look up the word history (Etymonline or the OED) and record the language of origin and the root meaning in your etymology log.

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Present the historical and literary background.
Here is what the first readers of The Tell-Tale Heart would have known. Poe published the story in 1843. Insanity was a live legal question: the 1843 M'Naghten case in Britain set the test for an insanity defense in the same year. Poe's narrators often argue their own case. Why does this story matter? It is one of the most taught examples of an unreliable first-person narrator; every claim of calm reason undercuts itself. Write down one question you want answered.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Teacher models a think-aloud on the anchor passage for point of view.
Watch me read this the way a careful reader does. The passage opens: "I kept quite still and said nothing." I stop and ask: what is the author doing here, and how does it connect to guilt that the mind cannot hide? I circle "watches", one of today's words, and ask why the author chose it over a plainer word. When I find point of view, I underline it and write its effect in the margin, then I check my idea against the next sentence.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Read the anchor passage aloud together; annotate for point of view.
Now we do it together. I read the first sentence and you track along. Mark every example of point of view. Turn to a partner: what does the author want us to notice? I will collect three ideas and we choose the strongest using evidence.

> *I kept quite still and said nothing. For a whole hour I did not move a muscle, and in the mean time I did not hear him lie down. He was still sitting up in the bed, listening;—just as I have done, night after night, hearkening to the death watches in the wall.*

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Students annotate a new passage independently in the reader, then begin the writing prompt at their assigned rigor level.
Your turn. Annotate the next page in the app for Point of view, Irony, Imagery: at least three marks with a margin note each. Then open your writing prompt; the app shows the level your teacher assigned (for a 9–10 class, the HS Sophomore prompt reads: Analyze how The Tell-Tale Heart develops the idea of guilt that the mind cannot hide. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of point of view and irony shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) I will circulate and conference.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions (focus set for the class level): wait time, think-pair-share on DOK 3/4, follow-up probes.
Let's talk. We move from what happens to why it matters to whether it's right. After each question I wait before calling on anyone: think first. Our anchor question: How does this story connect to guilt and conscience? Every claim needs a page reference. Respond to the person before you by agreeing, extending or challenging with evidence, and end by writing one question of your own.

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Story quiz in the app, then a one-sentence exit ticket.
Take the story quiz in the app. Then, in one sentence, tell me what this story suggests about guilt that the mind cannot hide, backed by one short quotation.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how point of view shapes guilt that the mind cannot hide. Tonight, read the next story and add two words to your etymology log.

Total: 90 minutes.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
dismembered (verb)	cut a body into pieces	*First of all I dismembered the corpse.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
suavity (noun)	smooth, polished politeness	*There entered three men, who introduced themselves, with perfect suavity, as officers of the police.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
dissemble (verb)	to hide one's true feelings	*"Villains!" I shrieked, "dissemble no more!*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
dissimulation (noun)	hiding one's true feelings or intentions	*You should have seen how wisely I proceeded—with what caution—with what foresight—with what dissimulation I went to work!*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
uncontrollable (adjective)	difficult to solve or alleviate	*And now at the dead hour of the night, amid the dreadful silence of that old house, so strange a noise as this excited me to uncontrollable terror.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
strides (noun)	a step in walking or running	*I paced the floor to and fro with heavy strides, as if excited to fury by the observations of the men—but the noise steadily increased.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
watches (noun)	a small portable timepiece	*He was still sitting up in the bed, listening;—just as I have done, night after night, hearkening to the death watches in the wall.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
premises (noun)	assumptions an argument is based on	*A shriek had been heard by a neighbor during the night; suspicion of foul play had been aroused; information had been lodged at the police office, and they (the officers) had been deputed to search the premises.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
		Anything was more tolerable than this derision!	

tolerable (adjective)	capable of being borne or endured		Student look-up (not yet verified)

Discussion questions

1. The narrator keeps telling us he is not mad. Why might someone insist so hard on a point?
2. Where does point of view appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with guilt and conscience?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What does the narrator say drove him to kill the old man? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: The old man's pale 'vulture' eye
2. How many nights does the narrator watch the old man before acting? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Seven, killing him on the eighth
3. Where does the narrator hide the body? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Under the floorboards of the chamber
4. Why do the police come to the house? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A neighbor heard a shriek in the night
5. What makes the narrator confess? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A beating sound he believes is the dead man's heart
6. Retell the three most important events of “The Tell-Tale Heart” in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: An unnamed narrator insists he is sane while describing how the old man's pale blue 'vulture eye' drove him to murder. He spies on the old man for seven nights, kills him on the eighth, dismembers the body and hides it under the floorboards. When police arrive he chats calmly, but a beating sound he believes is the dead man's heart grows louder until he shrieks a confession.
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in “The Tell-Tale Heart”? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does “The Tell-Tale Heart” take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: “First of all I dismembered the corpse.” What does “dismembered” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: dismembered: cut a body into pieces.

10. Reread: “There entered three men, who introduced themselves, with perfect suavity, as officers of the police.” What does “suavity” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: suavity: smooth, polished politeness.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does “The Tell-Tale Heart” suggest about guilt that the mind cannot hide? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: It is one of the most taught examples of an unreliable first-person narrator; every claim of calm reason undercuts itself.
2. Find one example of point of view in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for who is telling the story and what that narrator can and cannot know.
3. How does the irony in this story shape what we understand about guilt that the mind cannot hide? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true.
4. In the passage that begins “I kept quite still and said nothing.”, why might Poe have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “The Tell-Tale Heart”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: An unnamed narrator insists he is sane while describing how the old man's pale blue 'vulture eye' drove him to murder. He spies on the old man for seven nights, kills him on the eighth, dismembers the body and hides it under the floorboards. When police arrive he chats calmly, but a beating sound…
6. As the opening story, what does “The Tell-Tale Heart” set up that the rest of The Tell-Tale Heart will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
8. The bell-ringer asked: “The narrator keeps telling us he is not mad. Why might someone insist so hard on a point?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does imagery appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with guilt and conscience? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for sensory details (sight, sound, cold, light) and what mood they create.
10. Background: Poe published the story in 1843. Insanity was a live legal question: the 1843 M'Naghten case in Britain set the test for an insanity defense in the same year. Poe's narrators often argue their own case. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: "It is one of the most taught examples of an unreliable first-person narrator; every claim of calm reason undercuts itself." How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
3. Rewrite one moment of "The Tell-Tale Heart" from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about guilt that the mind cannot hide? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
4. Write three questions of your own about "The Tell-Tale Heart": one recall, one "why/how", and one "should/what if". Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
5. Connect this story to the unreliable mind: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Poe need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
6. Is the point of view in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
7. Compare how "The Tell-Tale Heart" treats guilt that the mind cannot hide with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does The Tell-Tale Heart see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
8. As the final story, does this ending resolve guilt and conscience? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about guilt that the mind cannot hide? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
10. What question would you most like to ask Edgar Allan Poe about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.

Annotation focus

- **Point of view:** look for who is telling the story and what that narrator can and cannot know (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Irony**: gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true
- Also notice **Imagery**: sensory details (sight, sound, cold, light) and what mood they create

Chapter quiz

1. What does the narrator say drove him to kill the old man?

   A. The old man's pale 'vulture' eye

B. A quarrel over rent

C. An insult from the old man

D. The old man's money

2. How many nights does the narrator watch the old man before acting?

A. Thirty

B. Three

C. One

D. Seven, killing him on the eighth

3. Where does the narrator hide the body?

A. In the garden

B. Under the floorboards of the chamber

C. In the river

D. In the cellar wall

4. Why do the police come to the house?

A. A neighbor heard a shriek in the night

B. The old man's son reports him missing

C. They are searching for a thief

D. The narrator calls them

5. What makes the narrator confess?

A. The police find the body

B. He finds the old man's will

C. A witness accuses him

D. A beating sound he believes is the dead man's heart

6. In the line “First of all I dismembered the corpse.”, what does “dismembered” most nearly mean?

A. to hide one's true feelings

B. hiding one's true feelings or intentions

C. cut a body into pieces

D. smooth, polished politeness

7. In the line “There entered three men, who introduced themselves, with perfect suavity, as officers of the police.”, what does “suavity” most nearly mean?

A. cut a body into pieces

B. hiding one's true feelings or intentions

C. to hide one's true feelings

D. smooth, polished politeness

Answer key: 1. A (The old man's pale 'vulture' eye); 2. D (Seven, killing him on the eighth); 3. B (Under the floorboards of the chamber); 4. A (A neighbor heard a shriek in the night); 5. D (A beating sound he believes is the dead man's heart); 6. C (cut a body into pieces); 7. D (smooth, polished politeness)

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.6, W.7.1; Indiana 2023: 7.RC.1, 7.W.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this story is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In "The Tell-Tale Heart," how does Poe show guilt that the mind cannot hide? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the point of view you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.6, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.W.1): In The Tell-Tale Heart, how does Poe develop the idea of guilt that the mind cannot hide? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the point of view in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.6, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.W.1): Analyze how The Tell-Tale Heart develops the idea of guilt that the mind cannot hide. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of point of view and irony shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3): Analyze how the structure of The Tell-Tale Heart (where it begins, turns and ends) and its point of view shape the reader's understanding of guilt that the mind cannot hide. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.6, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5): Two readers disagree about what The Tell-Tale Heart suggests about guilt that the mind cannot hide. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's point of view and irony), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

AP (650 words; AP: AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: RL.11-12.6, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Edgar Allan Poe uses point of view in The Tell-Tale Heart to complicate the reader's understanding of guilt that the mind cannot hide. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate The Tell-Tale Heart within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of guilt that the mind cannot hide responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read The Tell-Tale Heart alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of guilt that the mind cannot hide follows or bends those conventions, using the point of view as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to The Tell-Tale Heart and its treatment of guilt that the mind cannot hide. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's point of view and irony, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads The Tell-Tale Heart as evidence for a larger claim about guilt that the mind cannot hide in The Tell-Tale Heart. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads The Tell-Tale Heart as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of guilt that the mind cannot hide. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on The Tell-Tale Heart.

SAT-style questions

1. *"Villains!" I shrieked, "dissemble no more!*

   As used in the text, what does the word “dissemble” most nearly mean?

   A. to hide one's true feelings

   B. capable of being borne or endured

   C. assumptions an argument is based on

   D. a small portable timepiece

2. *I kept quite still and said nothing. For a whole hour I did not move a muscle, and in the mean time I did not hear him lie down. He was still sitting up in the bed, listening;—just as I have done, night after night, hearkening to the death watches in the wall.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “The Tell-Tale Heart”?

   A. Guilt that the mind cannot hide

   B. Revenge carried out with perfect control

   C. A girl's first encounter with death across the class line

   D. The cost of wanting to seem richer than you are

SAT key: 1. A (to hide one's true feelings); 2. A (Guilt that the mind cannot hide)

Whole-book test

The Tell-Tale Heart: whole-book test · 90 minutes

Part I: Multiple choice

1. What does the narrator say drove him to kill the old man?
   A. The old man's pale 'vulture' eye
   B. A quarrel over rent
   C. An insult from the old man
   D. The old man's money
2. How many nights does the narrator watch the old man before acting?
   A. Thirty
   B. Three
   C. One
   D. Seven, killing him on the eighth
3. Where does the narrator hide the body?
   A. In the garden
   B. Under the floorboards of the chamber
   C. In the river
   D. In the cellar wall
4. Why do the police come to the house?
   A. A neighbor heard a shriek in the night
   B. The old man's son reports him missing
   C. They are searching for a thief
   D. The narrator calls them
5. What makes the narrator confess?
   A. The police find the body
   B. He finds the old man's will
   C. A witness accuses him
   D. A beating sound he believes is the dead man's heart
6. In the line “First of all I dismembered the corpse.”, what does “dismembered” most nearly mean?
   A. to hide one's true feelings
   B. hiding one's true feelings or intentions
   C. cut a body into pieces
   D. smooth, polished politeness

7. In the line “There entered three men, who introduced themselves, with perfect suavity, as officers of the police.”, what does “suavity” most nearly mean?
   A. cut a body into pieces
   B. hiding one's true feelings or intentions
   C. to hide one's true feelings
   D. smooth, polished politeness
8. As used in the story (“First of all I dismembered the corpse.”), what does “dismembered” mean?
   A. cut a body into pieces
   B. difficult to solve or alleviate
   C. assumptions an argument is based on
   D. to hide one's true feelings
9. As used in the story (“There entered three men, who introduced themselves, with perfect suavity, as officers of the police.”), what does “suavity” mean?
   A. a step in walking or running
   B. smooth, polished politeness
   C. capable of being borne or endured
   D. hiding one's true feelings or intentions
10. As used in the story (“"Villains!" I shrieked, "dissemble no more!”), what does “dissemble” mean?
    A. a small portable timepiece
    B. cut a body into pieces
    C. to hide one's true feelings
    D. difficult to solve or alleviate
11. As used in the story (“You should have seen how wisely I proceeded—with what caution—with what foresight—with what dissimulation I went to work!”), what does “dissimulation” mean?
    A. assumptions an argument is based on
    B. smooth, polished politeness
    C. a step in walking or running
    D. hiding one's true feelings or intentions
12. As used in the story (“And now at the dead hour of the night, amid the dreadful silence of that old house, so strange a noise as this excited me to uncontrollable ”), what does “uncontrollable” mean?
    A. difficult to solve or alleviate
    B. capable of being borne or endured
    C. to hide one's true feelings
    D. a small portable timepiece

Part II: Short answer

1. Explain how guilt and conscience develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
2. Explain how the unreliable mind develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
3. Explain how obsession develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

Part III: Essay

Choose one of the story's central concerns (guilt and conscience, the unreliable mind, obsession) and argue how the ending reframes it.

Answer key

Answer key: 1. A (The old man's pale 'vulture' eye); 2. D (Seven, killing him on the eighth); 3. B (Under the floorboards of the chamber); 4. A (A neighbor heard a shriek in the night); 5. D (A beating sound he believes is the dead man's heart); 6. C (cut a body into pieces); 7. D (smooth, polished politeness); 8. A (cut a body into pieces); 9. B (smooth, polished politeness); 10. C (to hide one's true feelings); 11. D (hiding one's true feelings or intentions); 12. A (difficult to solve or alleviate)

Essay assignments

Essay: Guilt and conscience

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Tell-Tale Heart teaches about guilt and conscience. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Edgar Allan Poe develops guilt and conscience in The Tell-Tale Heart. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Edgar Allan Poe develops guilt and conscience across The Tell-Tale Heart. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Tell-Tale Heart (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of guilt and conscience. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of guilt and conscience in The Tell-Tale Heart. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Edgar Allan Poe's choices in The Tell-Tale Heart (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of guilt and conscience, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Tell-Tale Heart's treatment of guilt and conscience in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on guilt and conscience in The Tell-Tale Heart that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on guilt and conscience in The Tell-Tale Heart. Name your critical

method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about guilt and conscience in The Tell-Tale Heart, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on guilt and conscience in The Tell-Tale Heart, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: The unreliable mind

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Tell-Tale Heart teaches about the unreliable mind. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Edgar Allan Poe develops the unreliable mind in The Tell-Tale Heart. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Edgar Allan Poe develops the unreliable mind across The Tell-Tale Heart. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Tell-Tale Heart (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of the unreliable mind. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of the unreliable mind in The Tell-Tale Heart. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Edgar Allan Poe's choices in The Tell-Tale Heart (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of the unreliable mind, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Tell-Tale Heart's treatment of the unreliable mind in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on the unreliable mind in The Tell-Tale Heart that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on the unreliable mind in The Tell-Tale Heart. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about the unreliable mind in The Tell-Tale Heart, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on the unreliable mind in The Tell-Tale Heart, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Obsession

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Tell-Tale Heart teaches about obsession. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Edgar Allan Poe develops obsession in The Tell-Tale Heart. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Edgar Allan Poe develops obsession across The Tell-Tale Heart. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Tell-Tale Heart (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of obsession. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of obsession in The Tell-Tale Heart. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Edgar Allan Poe's choices in The Tell-Tale Heart (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of obsession, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Tell-Tale Heart's treatment of obsession in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on obsession in The Tell-Tale Heart that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on obsession in The Tell-Tale Heart. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about obsession in The Tell-Tale Heart, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on obsession in The Tell-Tale Heart, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Original Liber et Libri curriculum. Quotations from the public-domain text. Vocabulary definitions are modern and contextual (curated; based on Princeton WordNet 3.0). Word histories appear only where verified (Online Etymology Dictionary, 2026-10-20); other words are student look-ups. AP and Cambridge entries are our own summaries with links, not College Board or Cambridge text; ICC-WC and LeL IDs are Liber et Libri labels. Included with every curriculum purchase and with Classroom Pro.